

DUTCH GLORY

Spanish naval predominance survived the maritime disaster of the 1588 Armada. Further expeditions were planned against England and magnificent ships built for new Armadas. But in the 17th century, as Spanish financial and military resources began to decline, the Dutch seized the opportunity not only to win their independence but to become a global sea power.

Dutch privateers and irregular coastal forces had performed well against the Spanish in the 16th century, but the Dutch flowering in the first half of the 17th century was on an altogether different scale. The ships of the Dutch East India Company ruthlessly supplanted the Portuguese in much of Asia, most profitably in Indonesia, creating a fabulously wealthy trading empire. In the Americas the Dutch attacked Portuguese and Spanish colonies and their privateers stole a fortune in Spanish silver.

By the 1630s Spain could no longer communicate with its forces fighting in the Netherlands by sea, having to send arms, supplies, and pay for their troops overland from Italy. Dutch dominance of their home waters was confirmed in spectacular fashion by their total annihilation of a Spanish fleet at the Downs in 1639, a battle that marked the eclipse of Spain as a major naval power.

Galleon against galley
In a clash off the coast of the Netherlands in the early 17th century, a Dutch galleon gets the better of two Spanish galleys, sinking one of them by ramming.